

All hail the app internet, rise of smarter apps

Apps will increasingly become personal windows to the Web

A combination of factors is helping drive the smartphone and tablet industry to ever greater heights. Great hardware alone can't make a successful tablet. An important ingredient of the winning formula is the abundance of apps available for the customer, whether it's an iPad or Android tablet -- just ask the PlayBook guys. A crucial component of the tablet experience is the apps you interact with, be it games, feeds, or any other activity. But there's a significant, almost fundamental change happening in the way these apps function, and going forward they're going to be our gateways to the internet.

The app internet

Our infatuation with apps isn't a "bubble" waiting to explode and crash-land us back to earth in the wake of a global economic slowdown expected this year. Analysts believe we are increasingly altering the manner in which we interact with the internet, and it's no longer with a traditional web browser. More people are accessing the web, utilizing services deployed over a cloud infrastructure through mobile apps. This number is only going to increase in 2012. According to Forrester Research, the app industry is worth US \$2.2 billion currently, and as many as 41 per cent of companies are now moving away from Web-based software toward the app internet.

According to an IDC estimate, cloud services will grow four times faster than the industry rate and amount for US \$36 billion

DEATH OF CABLE BOX

That's right, it's already happening, if you didn't know already. Increasingly in Europe and North America, game consoles and Smart TVs are replacing the age-old cable TV box. We all welcome this trend. It removes the hassle of managing an additional device, gives the user a simple experience and it's a cost-effective solution for the cable company. Hopefully, old black boxes will be history soon.

of global development and deployment of cloud services. Close to 80 per cent of apps to be released this year will have a cloud backbone for providing service to their consumers. With Apple's iTunes and Google's Android Market surpassing their 15 billionth and 10 billionth app download mark, respectively, last year, these two platforms will pretty much spearhead the app internet's outreach to the end user.

Apps get smarter

Just like app internet is set to explode this year, the need for smarter, intelligent apps is an important stepping stone towards that direction. NFC or Near Field Communication will take huge steps towards becoming a mainstream feature on most smartphones this year. In fact, a CNN report mentions that by 2013, one in every five cell phones will be NFC-equipped. Also big on the 2012 agenda is the surge in context-aware apps, which is an extension of location-aware apps that are currently the trend.

Context-aware apps, powered by an intelligent cloud infrastructure, could take human machine interaction to the next level. Imagine you're a cricket fan who loves eating hotdogs, and the app in your phone suggesting you a good hotdog joint and of a scheduled match while you're driving around in downtown Auckland, for example. A bevy of social media features embedded within these context-aware apps will help you share and stay connected with your friends. So, the general end user experience from an app will be richer, more enriching in the coming year.

We might also see a Siri-clone later this year, which would be a rather extensive and



“ The need towards emotional intelligence has also started rising, hence, tablets/smartphones equipped with voice commands or other similar features, wouldn't come as a surprise. ”

Rajesh Thadani, Director,
Consumer Business, Lenovo India

across-the-board deployment of a smart app. A smart, virtual assistant with intelligent speech recognition for your mobile phone who's aware of who you are, where you are, your likes, dislikes and a lot more—who wouldn't want that?

HTML5 on the rise

And finally HTML5 apps will surge in 2012, finding widespread acceptance among the developer community. HTML5 is the long-awaited magic wand which allows developers to create an app once and have it work everywhere: iOS, Android, Windows Phone, Symbian, Bada, etc. No need of different apps for different platforms. The acceptance of HTML5 apps will also ensure a faster roll-out time for apps, which eventually leads to a faster rate of app development. Here's to an app-filled 2012! 